are Protestant, conservative Indonesians are Muslim, and conservative Thais are Buddhist. In tsarist Russia, to be conservative meant to support the tsar. In the USSR of the 1980s, to be conservative meant to support communist traditions and oppose glasnost, perestroika and democratisation. In the United States of the 1980s, to be conservative meant to support American democratic traditions and oppose communism and totalitarianism.[19]

Yet in the 2010s and early 2020s, conservative parties in numerous democracies have been hijacked by unconservative leaders such as Donald Trump and have been transformed into radical revolutionary parties. Instead of doing their best to conserve existing institutions and traditions, the new brand of conservative parties like the US Republican Party is highly suspicious of them. For example, they reject the traditional respect owed to scientists, civil servants and other serving elites, and view them instead with contempt. They similarly attack fundamental democratic institutions and traditions such as elections, refusing to concede defeat and to transfer power graciously. Instead of a Burkean programme of conservation, the Trumpian programme talks more of destroying existing institutions and revolutionising society. The founding moment of Burkean conservatism was the storming of the Bastille, which Burke viewed with horror. On 6 January 2021, many Trump supporters observed the storming of the US Capitol with enthusiasm. Trump supporters may explain that existing institutions are so dysfunctional that there is just no alternative to destroying them and building entirely new structures from scratch. But irrespective of whether this view is right or wrong, this is a quintessential revolutionary rather than conservative view. The conservative suicide has taken progressives utterly by surprise and has forced progressive parties like the US Democratic Party to become the guardians of the old order and of established institutions.

Nobody knows for sure why all this is happening. One hypothesis is that the accelerating pace of technological change with its attendant economic, social and cultural transformations might have made the moderate conservative programme seem unrealistic. If conserving existing traditions and institutions is hopeless, and some kind of revolution looks inevitable, then the only means to thwart a left-wing revolution is by striking first and instigating a right-wing revolution. This was the political logic in the 1920s and 1930s, when conservative forces backed radical fascist revolutions in